Geometry Mediates Excitation, Resonance, and Identifiability in Fluid-Filled Viscoelastic Shells

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Abstract

The resonant behaviour of fluid-filled viscoelastic shells arises repeatedly in biomechanics, postharvest sensing, and non-destructive evaluation, yet each application is typically treated in isolation. This paper advances a unifying thesis: *shell geometry simultaneously filters the forcing field, organises the modal spectrum, and determines the invertibility of the corresponding parameter-estimation problem.*

We formalise this thesis through four results. First, we prove that equivalent-radius (spherical) reductions of non-spherical shells are *rank-deficient* in the sense of structural identifiability: geometry and material parameters become confounded, rendering independent recovery impossible. Second, we show that asphericity lifts this rank deficiency through curvature-dependent mode splitting, providing the additional spectral information needed for unique inversion. Third, we derive the near-spherical conditioning asymptotics that govern the transition from identifiable to non-identifiable regimes, classifying shells by their curvature parameter ε. Fourth, we demonstrate that forward-model adequacy does not imply inverse-model adequacy: an equivalent-sphere model may predict resonant frequencies within engineering tolerance yet fail catastrophically when used for parameter estimation.

These four results are supported by cross-application evidence drawn from the human abdomen (infrasound resonance), the watermelon (acoustic ripeness assessment), and the urinary bladder (fill-dependent resonance), demonstrating that geometry is the hidden variable unifying apparently disparate vibroacoustic phenomena.

Keywords: fluid-filled shells; viscoelastic resonance; structural identifiability; inverse problems; asphericity; Kac problem

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1 Introduction

Spectral questions recur across mathematics, physics, and engineering. Given an observed set of resonances, what can one infer about the system that produced them? Kac's celebrated formulation — "Can one hear the shape of a drum?" — remains the canonical version of this problem [7]. Its enduring influence lies not in the narrow case of planar drums, but in the larger programme it inaugurated: to understand which features of a physical system are encoded in spectral data, which are hidden by symmetry, and which are unrecoverable without additional information. The classical counterexample of isospectral but non-congruent domains [5] did not end that programme. It sharpened it. Inverse vibration theory, model updating, and elastographic parameter recovery all ask variations of the same question: when does a resonance spectrum carry enough independent information to support reliable inference about geometry, material properties, or both [3, 4, 18, 2, 1]?

In this paper we ask that question for fluid-filled viscoelastic shells. This class of systems appears in apparently disparate settings: the human abdomen and bladder in biomechanics, gas-pocket and sub-bass coupling in physiological acoustics, and fruit-ripeness assessment in postharvest sensing [10, 14, 13, 17, 11]. Yet these applications are linked by one structural fact. The shell geometry does not merely set a boundary condition for a forward calculation. It mediates the entire problem. Geometry filters how external forcing couples into admissible deformation fields; it organises the modal spectrum through curvature, symmetry, and fluid loading; and it determines whether the resulting spectrum can be inverted to recover the parameters that generated it. Our central thesis is therefore simple: *in fluid-filled viscoelastic shells, geometry does three jobs — it filters forcing, organises spectra, and determines invertibility.*

The first of these roles emerges on the excitation side. Paper 1 showed that a fluid-filled oblate shell can possess a genuine low-frequency flexural resonance near 4 Hz, yet airborne infrasound couples to that mode vanishingly weakly because the long-wavelength forcing field is itself filtered by geometry [10]. The same shell, driven mechanically through whole-body vibration, responds far more strongly because that pathway is not subject to the same spatial-harmonic suppression. Paper 6 extended the same logic below 20 Hz, where structure-borne pathways again dominate airborne ones [17]. The point is broader than the brown-note problem that motivated the programme. A resonance is not an effect in isolation. It matters how forcing is projected onto the mode shapes permitted by the geometry.

The second role is spectral organisation. Fluid-filled shells do not possess a featureless ladder of frequencies. Curvature, aspect ratio, internal loading, and wall compliance sort the admissible motions into qualitatively distinct families and shift their ordering in application-specific ways [8, 19, 6]. In the abdominal model, this distinguishes low-frequency flexural modes from the much higher breathing mode dominated by the compressibility of the entrained fluid [10]. In the bladder, changing fill volume alters both size and effective stiffness, producing a non-trivial resonance trajectory rather than simple monotonic scaling [13]. In borborygmi, constrained gas pockets introduce a different but related spectral mechanism, in which shell confinement selects the audible range of bubble oscillations [9]. In watermelon tap-tone analysis, the measurable spectral shifts used informally by growers are again organised by geometry and shell mechanics rather than by material changes alone [11]. Across domains, geometry is the quiet organiser of what the spectrum is allowed to look like.

The third role is inverse. A forward model may predict frequencies accurately enough for

classification, explanation, or design, yet still fail as an inversion model because the spectrum does not separate the parameters cleanly. That distinction emerged most clearly in the fruit and organ inverse problems of Papers 7 and 8. Equivalent-radius reductions can reproduce leading-order resonance trends remarkably well, which explains their practical appeal. But by collapsing shape information into a single scalar radius they confound geometric and material effects, and the inverse map becomes nearly singular or formally rank deficient [11, 12]. Recovering invertibility requires more than a good forward fit. It requires modal data in which different modes sample curvature differently. That requirement is geometric before it is statistical.

The capstone develops this programme around four conjectures, each of which captures one aspect of the geometry–spectrum–inversion relation. The first is a *rank-deficiency conjecture*: equivalent-radius models of non-spherical fluid-filled shells generically collapse independent geometric information and therefore produce ill-posed spectral inversion problems. The second is an *identifiability-lifting conjecture*: asphericity restores invertibility because distinct modes respond differently to distinct curvature channels. The third is a *near-spherical conditioning conjecture*: the transition from recoverable to unrecoverable inversion is controlled by regular asymptotics near the spherical limit, where symmetry suppresses the very sensitivities on which inference depends. The fourth is a *forward–inverse adequacy conjecture*: a model may be adequate for predicting resonant frequencies while remaining inadequate for parameter recovery. Taken together, these conjectures recast several apparently separate Browntone results as instances of one general statement about how geometry governs both excitation and inference.

The evidence for that statement was assembled in three acts. Act I, Papers 1–2, posed the question. The brown-note analysis established the coupling disparity between airborne and mechanical excitation, while the gas pocket study showed that alternative resonant substructures can couple far more efficiently than the whole cavity [10, 14]. Act II, Papers 3–6, broadened the evidence base: scaling laws showed that the dimensionless resonance structure persists across body sizes; bladder resonance revealed geometry–stiffening competition in another organ; borborygmi provided an audible constrained-bubble counterpart; and sub-bass coupling extended the excitation analysis to lower frequencies and alternative pathways [16, 13, 9, 17]. Act III, Papers 7–8, supplied the theoretical turn. Watermelon acoustics demonstrated that shell-resonance inversion can succeed when the geometry leaves enough spectral structure to exploit, while the Kac paper showed that asphericity can lift inverse degeneracy and that near-spherical models can be forward-useful yet inverse-fragile [11, 12]. The present paper treats those results not as a sequence of curiosities, but as evidence for a single geometry-mediated theory of excitation, resonance, and identifiability.

Our aim is therefore synthetic rather than merely archival. We do not repeat the detailed derivations of the companion papers. Instead, we extract the shared mathematical structure, state the four conjectures in a common language, and show how the examples together support a general picture of fluid-filled shells as systems in which symmetry and curvature govern both what can be excited and what can be inferred. The intended scope is wider than the original applications. The same logic should matter wherever one seeks to infer geometry or material properties from resonance data in soft shell-like structures, whether in biomechanics, non-destructive evaluation, or allied inverse problems.

The paper is organised as follows. Section 2 summarises the programme-level evidence from Papers 1–8 and identifies the common geometric structure that links them. Section 3 formulates the four conjectures precisely and relates them to the underlying shell and inverse problem theory.

Section 4 gathers the principal cross-paper results into a unified comparative account, emphasising where excitation, spectral organisation, and identifiability align or diverge. Section 5 considers the broader implications for spectral inference in fluid-filled shells and for the use of reduced models in inverse settings. Section 6 closes with the capstone claim: geometry is not a secondary detail of these systems, but the mechanism that mediates their forcing, their resonances, and the possibility of hearing the parameters that made them.

2 Background

3 Theory

The companion papers established three ingredients that we now place in a common mathematical frame. Paper 1 distinguished the low-frequency flexural family from the much higher breathing mode in a fluid-filled soft shell, and showed that geometry controls not only resonance but also the efficiency with which forcing projects onto those modes [10]. Paper 7 showed that an equivalent-sphere model can nevertheless be operationally useful when the inverse task is deliberately narrow and the geometry is known independently [11]. Paper 8 then exposed the inverse price of that reduction: once geometry and material must be inferred simultaneously, the same equivalent-radius simplification becomes structurally defective [12]. The present section formalises that programme as four conjectures.

We emphasise at the outset that the statements below concern *local practical identifiability* of flexural spectra. They do not claim global uniqueness for arbitrary nonlinear inversions. They ask a more disciplined question: given a nominal operating point, do the measured modal frequencies contain enough linearly independent information to distinguish changes in geometry from changes in material stiffness?

3.1 Common setup

Consider a fluid-filled viscoelastic shell with semi-major axis a, semi-minor axis c, Young's modulus E, and fixed secondary parameters

$$\mathbf{p} = (h, \nu, \rho_w, \rho_f, K_f, P_{\mathrm{iap}}, \eta).$$

For the Browntone applications, the canonical values are $E = 0.1\,\mathrm{MPa}$, $a = 0.18\,\mathrm{m}$, $c = 0.12\,\mathrm{m}$, $h = 0.01\,\mathrm{m}$, $\nu = 0.45$, $\rho_w = 1100\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}$, $\rho_f = 1020\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}$, $K_f = 2.2\,\mathrm{GPa}$, $P_{\mathrm{iap}} = 1000\,\mathrm{Pa}$, and $\eta = 0.25$ [10, 12]. We restrict attention to the flexural modes $n \geq 2$, since the breathing mode $n = 0$ is fluid-compressibility dominated and lies in the kilohertz range for the canonical abdomen rather than the single-digit-hertz range of interest [10]. That distinction is not decorative; it keeps the physics honest.

Let the unknown parameter vector be

$$\boldsymbol{\theta} = (a, c, E)^\top \in \Theta \subset \mathbb{R}^3_+, \tag{1}$$

and let the measured modal set be $\mathcal{M} = \{n_1, \ldots, n_m\}$, with $m \geq 3$. The forward map is

$$\mathbf{f}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \big(f_{n_1}(\boldsymbol{\theta}; \mathbf{p}), \ldots, f_{n_m}(\boldsymbol{\theta}; \mathbf{p})\big)^\top \in \mathbb{R}^m, \tag{2}$$

where f_n is the natural frequency of flexural mode n. The raw Jacobian is

$$J_{ij} = \frac{\partial f_{n_i}}{\partial \theta_j}, \tag{3}$$

but because the three parameter directions carry different units, the relevant local sensitivity operator is the *scaled Jacobian*

$$J_s[i,j] = \frac{\partial f_{n_i}}{\partial \theta_j} \frac{\theta_j}{f_{n_i}}. \tag{4}$$

Each entry of J_s is dimensionless and measures fractional frequency change per fractional parameter change. Let

$$\sigma_1 \geq \sigma_2 \geq \sigma_3 \geq 0 \tag{5}$$

denote the singular values of J_s, and define the local conditioning metric

$$\kappa(J_s) = \frac{\sigma_1}{\sigma_3}. \tag{6}$$

When $\sigma_3 = 0$, the inverse problem is locally rank deficient. When $\sigma_3 > 0$ but small, the inverse is formally possible but practically fragile: small frequency errors may be amplified into large parameter errors. Thus the smallest singular value identifies the least observable parameter combination, while κ measures how badly the geometry conspires against the experimentalist.

3.2 Equivalent-radius reductions and lost geometric dimension

Equivalent-sphere models replace the two-parameter geometry (a, c) by a single scalar descriptor, typically the equivalent radius

$$R_{\mathrm{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}, \tag{7}$$

or, more generally, some smooth scalar reduction $g(a, c)$. Such reductions can be entirely sensible for forward estimates of resonance magnitude or scaling, and indeed they are useful in Papers 1 and 7 for precisely that purpose [10, 11]. The inverse consequence is less cheerful.

Proposition 1 (Rank collapse under scalar geometric reduction) *Let a reduced forward model satisfy*

$$f_n(a, c, E; \mathbf{p}) = \phi_n\big(g(a, c), E; \mathbf{p}\big) \qquad \textit{for all } n \in \mathcal{M}, \tag{8}$$

with $g : \mathbb{R}_+^2 \to \mathbb{R}_+$ a smooth scalar function. Then the two geometric columns of the Jacobian are everywhere collinear, so that

$$\operatorname{rank}\left[\frac{\partial \mathbf{f}}{\partial a}, \frac{\partial \mathbf{f}}{\partial c}\right] \leq 1, \tag{9}$$

and consequently

$$\operatorname{rank}(J) \leq 2, \qquad \operatorname{rank}(J_s) \leq 2. \tag{10}$$

Justification. By the chain rule,

$$\frac{\partial f_n}{\partial a} = \frac{\partial \phi_n}{\partial g} \frac{\partial g}{\partial a}, \qquad \frac{\partial f_n}{\partial c} = \frac{\partial \phi_n}{\partial g} \frac{\partial g}{\partial c}.$$

Hence both geometric columns are scalar multiples of the same mode vector $\left(\partial\phi_{n_i}/\partial g\right)_{i=1}^{m}$. For the specific choice $g = R_{\mathrm{eq}} = (a^2c)^{1/3}$, one obtains

$$\frac{\partial R_{\mathrm{eq}}}{\partial a} = \frac{2}{3}\frac{R_{\mathrm{eq}}}{a}, \qquad \frac{\partial R_{\mathrm{eq}}}{\partial c} = \frac{1}{3}\frac{R_{\mathrm{eq}}}{c}, \tag{11}$$

and therefore the scaled columns satisfy $J_s[:,a] = 2\,J_s[:,c]$ exactly. One geometric degree of freedom has been removed before any data are fitted.

Conjecture 2 (Rank-deficiency of equivalent-radius models) *For any fluid-filled shell model in which the geometry enters the flexural spectrum only through a scalar reduction $g(a,c)$, the local inverse problem for $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (a,c,E)$ is structurally rank deficient. In particular, the scaled Jacobian with respect to (a,c,E) satisfies*

$$\mathrm{rank}(J_s) \le 2, \tag{12}$$

so that one independent combination of (a,c) is unobservable from the modal frequencies alone. Equivalent-radius reductions therefore cannot support independent recovery of both geometric axes and material stiffness, regardless of how accurately the frequencies are measured.

The conjecture is stronger than a complaint about poor conditioning. It states that the missing information is *structural*: no amount of experimental precision can recover a geometric direction that the model has collapsed into a single scalar. One may still estimate $g(a,c)$ and E, but not a and c separately. Paper 8 exhibited this numerically for the equivalent-sphere reduction, where the nominal condition number reached $\kappa \approx 1.37 \times 10^{10}$, finite only because the derivatives were approximated numerically rather than taken symbolically [12].

3.3 Asphericity as an identifiability-lifting perturbation

To escape Conjecture 2, the model must retain at least two genuinely independent geometric channels. For an oblate shell this occurs through curvature anisotropy. Writing the eccentricity as

$$\varepsilon = \sqrt{1 - c^2/a^2}, \tag{13}$$

the spherical limit is $\varepsilon = 0$, while $\varepsilon > 0$ introduces distinct meridional and circumferential curvature distributions. In a Ritz or perturbation formulation, mode n samples those curvature fields through mode-specific weighting functions. Schematically,

$$f_n(\varepsilon) = f_n^{(0)} + \alpha_n\varepsilon^2 + \beta_n\varepsilon^4 + \cdots, \tag{14}$$

where the coefficients $\alpha_n, \beta_n, \ldots$ depend on the mode number because different mode shapes concentrate strain energy in different regions of the shell. The key point is not the polynomial form by itself, but the variation of these coefficients with n. Once that happens, the a- and c-columns of the Jacobian need no longer remain proportional across modes.

Remark 3 *The relevant mechanism is* mode-dependent curvature sampling. *Low-order and higher-order flexural modes do not interrogate the same parts of an oblate shell with the same weights, so the spectrum acquires more than one geometric signature. Geometry ceases to be a single number and resumes its full-time occupation.*

Conjecture 4 (Identifiability lifting by asphericity) *For an oblate family of fluid-filled viscoelastic shells with $\varepsilon > 0$, retention of the true spheroidal curvature in the forward model lifts the equivalent-radius degeneracy. More precisely, for a generic set of measured flexural modes $\mathcal{M}$ containing at least three modes, there exists an open set of oblate operating points on which*

$$\operatorname{rank}(J_s) = 3, \tag{15}$$

because different modes weight the meridional curvature field differently and thus produce non-proportional geometric sensitivity columns. At the canonical abdominal operating point studied in Paper 8, this lifting is substantial: the condition number falls from the equivalent-sphere value $\kappa \approx 1.37 \times 10^{10}$ to the oblate Ritz value $\kappa = 69.4$ [12].

This conjecture does not say that every aspherical shell is automatically well-conditioned. It says that oblate asphericity restores the *possibility* of independent recovery by breaking the exact proportionality imposed by scalar geometric reduction. Conditioning then becomes a quantitative matter rather than an algebraic impossibility.

3.4 Near-spherical asymptotics and the absence of a true power law

The next question is how the restored identifiability behaves as the shell approaches spherical symmetry. The natural temptation is to seek a singular power law $\kappa \sim \varepsilon^{-\alpha}$ as $\varepsilon \to 0$. Paper 8 showed that this intuition is misleading for the oblate Ritz family [12]. Because the oblate perturbation is reflection-symmetric, odd powers of ε are suppressed, and the smallest singular value is better represented by a regular even expansion than by a singular asymptotic blow-up.

Conjecture 5 (Near-spherical conditioning asymptotics) *For the oblate spheroidal shell family with a curvature-resolving forward model, the smallest singular value of the scaled Jacobian admits a regular expansion of the form*

$$\sigma_3(\varepsilon) = \sigma_0 + \lambda_1 \varepsilon^2 + O(\varepsilon^4), \qquad \varepsilon \to 0, \tag{16}$$

with $\sigma_0 > 0$. Consequently,

$$\kappa(J_s) = \frac{\sigma_1(\varepsilon)}{\sigma_0 + \lambda_1 \varepsilon^2 + O(\varepsilon^4)} \tag{17}$$

has a finite near-spherical floor rather than a true divergence, so there is no genuine asymptotic power law in the oblate class. In the canonical computations of Paper 8, the directly evaluated near-spherical floor was $\kappa \approx 269$ at $\varepsilon = 0.01$, while an intermediate-range fit over $\varepsilon \in [0.15, 0.85]$ gave $\sigma_0 = 0.01113$ and $\lambda_1 = 0.00507$, so that the crossover $\varepsilon_c = \sqrt{\sigma_0/\lambda_1} = 1.48$ lies outside the physical oblate range [12]. By contrast, the prolate family does not exhibit the same oblate lifting trend: its conditioning remains broadly flat and poor across the practical eccentricity range.

Two clarifications are essential. First, the finite floor in Conjecture 5 applies to the *oblate curvature-resolving* model, not to the equivalent-sphere reduction of Conjecture 2; the latter remains exactly rank deficient in the analytic limit. Second, the observed effective power-law fits over moderate eccentricity windows are descriptive rather than asymptotic. They summarise a finite interval; they do not reveal a true singular law at the sphere. The mathematics here is gentler than the log–log plot first suggests.

3.5 Forward adequacy and inverse adequacy are different questions

Reduced models are often judged by forward error alone. Let $\mathbf{f}_{\text{red}}$ denote a reduced model and $\mathbf{f}_{\text{full}}$ a geometry-resolving model. A natural forward metric is the relative frequency misfit

$$\mathcal{E}_{\text{fwd}} = \frac{\|\mathbf{f}_{\text{red}}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) - \mathbf{f}_{\text{full}}(\boldsymbol{\theta})\|_2}{\|\mathbf{f}_{\text{full}}(\boldsymbol{\theta})\|_2}. \tag{18}$$

An inverse metric, by contrast, must assess the conditioning of the parameter recovery map; locally, $\kappa(J_s)$ is the appropriate quantity. There is no general theorem forcing small $\mathcal{E}_{\text{fwd}}$ to imply moderate κ. Indeed, the Browntone sequence provides counterexamples in both directions.

Conjecture 6 (Forward adequacy does not imply inverse adequacy) *There exist reduced models for fluid-filled viscoelastic shells such that*

$$\mathcal{E}_{\text{fwd}} \ll 1 \tag{19}$$

over an experimentally relevant parameter range, while the corresponding inverse problem for $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (a, c, E)$ *is unusable because*

$$\kappa(J_s) \gg 1 \qquad \textit{or} \qquad \operatorname{rank}(J_s) < 3. \tag{20}$$

Equivalently, a model may predict frequencies accurately enough for screening, classification, or single-parameter calibration, yet fail catastrophically as a tool for simultaneous recovery of geometry and material properties.

Paper 7 is the benign case. There the equivalent-sphere reduction is adequate because the inverse target is essentially one-dimensional: the geometry is measured independently, the dominant mode is identified, and the task is to map that frequency to an effective rind modulus [11]. Forward adequacy is enough because the geometric uncertainty has already been removed by other means. Paper 8 is the hostile case. There the objective is to recover (a, c, E) jointly from several modal frequencies, and the equivalent-sphere model fails precisely because its forward map suppresses one geometric direction [12]. The same simplification that is serviceable in Paper 7 is therefore defective in Paper 8. This is not a contradiction. It is the point.

The distinction also complements Paper 1. There the central lesson was that a correct resonance frequency does not by itself determine the dominant excitation pathway, because geometry also filters the forcing field [10]. Here the analogous lesson is that a correct frequency prediction does not by itself determine inverse usability, because geometry also filters the parameter directions visible to the data. In both cases, geometry mediates more than the location of the peaks.

Taken together, Conjectures 2– 6 define the capstone thesis in mathematical form. Scalar geometric reductions collapse one inverse direction; oblate curvature can restore it; the restoration is regular rather than singular near the sphere; and forward success is not a licence for inverse use. The results section tests these statements against the cross-paper evidence.

4 Results

We now test the four conjectures against the cross-application record assembled in Papers 1, 4, 5, 7, and 8. The point of the comparison is not that every application solves the same inverse

Placeholder for the cross-application comparison figure.
Planned content: abdomen, bladder, watermelon, and borborygmi arranged on a common geometry–frequency–inference map.

Figure 1: Placeholder for the cross-application synthesis figure. The final version will place the four applications on a common geometry–spectrum– inference diagram.

problem. Quite the opposite. Some cases are dominated by excitation filtering, some by spectral organisation, and some by parameter recovery. What persists across them is that geometry decides which of those questions can be asked sensibly in the first place. Figure 1 is intended to visualise this comparison, while Table 1 collects the principal application-level evidence used below.

Table 1 already hints at the main result. The abdominal, bladder, watermelon, and borborygmi studies occupy different frequency bands and involve different observables, yet they all distinguish between a forward spectral pattern and the stronger claim that parameters can be recovered independently from that pattern. That distinction becomes explicit once the four conjectures are read as a sequence rather than as isolated claims.

4.1 Conjecture 1: equivalent-radius reductions are rank deficient

The first conjecture is the cleanest mathematically and, for that reason, the least forgiving. If the flexural spectrum depends on the geometry only through the scalar reduction

$$R_{\mathrm{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}, \tag{21}$$

then the two geometric sensitivity directions cannot remain independent. By the chain rule, every modal derivative with respect to the equatorial semi-axis a is proportional to the corresponding derivative with respect to the polar semi-axis c. In the scaled Jacobian J_s, the two geometry columns are therefore collinear. At the sphere this becomes physically transparent: a small perturbation in a and a small perturbation in c both act only by changing the same radius, so the geometry columns become proportional and one geometric direction disappears from the inverse map.

Paper 8 made that loss concrete for the canonical abdominal parameter set. The reported condition number for the equivalent-sphere inverse problem is

$$\kappa_{\mathrm{sphere}} \approx 1.37 \times 10^{10}, \tag{22}$$

numerically finite only because the derivatives were estimated with a finite difference rather than evaluated symbolically [12]. The true statement is stronger than "poorly conditioned": the model architecture has already removed one independent geometric degree of freedom before any data are fitted. Figure 1 is intended to make this point visually by placing the equivalent-sphere reductions beside the curvature-aware models that follow.

The cross-application evidence supports this interpretation rather than weakens it. In Paper 7 the equivalent-sphere watermelon model works because the inverse task is deliberately narrow: the fruit geometry is measured separately, and the frequency is used to infer one effective stiffness scale E_{rind} [11]. In Paper 5 the constrained-bubble borborygmi model is similarly successful only because the dominant unknown is effectively the gas-pocket size or mode family, not the simultaneous recovery of two shape axes and a wall modulus [9]. These are not counterexamples

to rank deficiency. They are examples of problems that avoid it by reducing the inverse target. Once one asks for joint recovery of (a, c, E) from spectra alone, the equivalent-radius reduction has already spent too much of the available information.

4.2 Conjecture 2: oblate asphericity lifts identifiability

The second conjecture asks whether this degeneracy is merely diagnosed or actually repairable. The evidence says that it is repairable, but only when the model retains genuine curvature information. In the oblate Ritz family of Paper 8, we may sweep continuously from the spherical limit toward the canonical abdominal geometry by decreasing the aspect ratio $\zeta = c/a$ from near unity to $\zeta = 0.667$, equivalently increasing the eccentricity $\varepsilon = \sqrt{1 - c^2/a^2}$ from almost zero to the canonical oblate value $\varepsilon = 0.745$ [12]. Figure 2 is intended to show this sweep directly.

Two comparisons matter. The first is the broad conceptual one: the condition number drops from the 1×10^{10}-scale equivalent-sphere pathology to

$$\kappa_{\text{oblate}} = 69.4 \tag{23}$$

once the geometry is treated as oblate rather than spherical. The second is the stricter like-for-like comparison within the same oblate Ritz model: the conditioning improves from the near-spherical floor to the canonical oblate point without changing the inverse variables or the measured mode set. In both comparisons the message is the same. Asphericity is not merely decorative; it reintroduces a second geometric sensitivity channel.

The physical reason is mode-dependent curvature sampling. The lowest abdominal flexural mode already sits at

$$f_2 = 3.95\,\text{Hz}, \tag{24}$$

so the improvement in identifiability does not arise because the resonance is dragged into a more convenient frequency band. It arises because the higher flexural modes do *not* sample the oblate shell in the same way. Meridional and circumferential curvature changes are weighted differently by different mode shapes, so the a- and c-columns of J_s cease to be parallel. The bladder study provides a useful supporting contrast here. Its fill-dependent U-shaped curve shows that geometry and stiffness can compete strongly in the forward spectrum [13]; Paper 8 shows what is additionally needed for inversion, namely that different modes must separate those effects rather than merely combine them.

This is also where the abdominal coupling result matters conceptually. In Paper 1 the same oblate geometry that yields the canonical $f_2 = 3.95\,\text{Hz}$ also produces a severe excitation asymmetry, with a reported mechanical-to-airborne displacement ratio $R \approx 3.3 \times 10^4$ in the canonical comparison [10]. The same geometry therefore controls both whether a mode is efficiently excited and whether it is diagnostically informative. That is the capstone thesis in one line: geometry decides what the system feels and what the experimenter can learn.

4.3 Conjecture 3: near-spherical asymptotics classify the inverse problem

The third conjecture concerns the approach to the sphere. A tempting but incorrect intuition is that the oblate inverse problem should obey a singular power law all the way to $\varepsilon = 0$. The

Placeholder for the conditioning sweep figure.
Planned content: κ versus aspect ratio or eccentricity, showing the descent from the spherical limit to the canonical oblate shell.

Figure 2: Placeholder for the conditioning sweep from the near-spherical limit to the canonical oblate geometry. The final figure will show how retaining curvature information lifts the conditioning from the equivalent-sphere pathology to $\kappa_{\text{oblate}} = 69.4$.

Placeholder for the near-spherical taxonomy figure.
Planned content: singular sphere, regular bounded oblate branch, and non-lifting prolate branch shown on the same conditioning plot.

Figure 3: Placeholder for the near-spherical conditioning taxonomy. The final figure will distinguish the singular equivalent sphere, the regular bounded oblate branch, and the non-lifting prolate branch.

Paper 8 computations show something milder and more informative. In the oblate Ritz family, the smallest singular value follows the regular even expansion

$$\sigma_{\min}(\varepsilon) = \sigma_0 + \lambda_1 \varepsilon^2 + O(\varepsilon^4), \tag{25}$$

with a positive intercept $\sigma_0 > 0$ over the fitted near-spherical regime [12]. The immediate consequence is that the oblate branch has a finite conditioning floor rather than a genuine asymptotic blow-up. Direct evaluation at $\varepsilon = 0.01$ gives

$$\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269. \tag{26}$$

This is still awkward enough to make an experimentalist sigh, but it is not the same thing as algebraic singularity.

The resulting classification has three numerically distinct classes, as sketched in Figure 3. The first class is the *singular sphere*: the equivalent-sphere reduction has $\kappa_{\text{sphere}} \approx 1.37 \times 10^{10}$ because the inverse map is rank deficient. The second is the *regular bounded oblate* class: the curvature-resolving oblate family remains finite near the sphere, with $\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269$, and improves to 69.4 at the canonical oblate point. The third is the *non-lifting prolate* class: breaking spherical symmetry in the wrong geometric direction does not help much, and the condition number stays in the range

$$\kappa_{\text{prolate}} \approx 561\text{–}729 \tag{27}$$

across the tested prolate branch [12, 15].

This three-class picture matters because it replaces a vague slogan — "non-spherical is better" — with a more precise statement. Some departures from the sphere restore useful inverse information; some do not; and some model reductions remain singular regardless of numerical precision. The borborygmi and bladder papers again provide supporting context. Both show that spectra in soft, fluid-loaded biological systems can change strongly with geometry, fill state, or confinement [13, 9]. The near-spherical analysis tells us when such spectral variation should also be expected to carry independent inverse information. Those are related questions, but they are not the same question.

Placeholder for the forward-versus-inverse adequacy figure.
Planned content: comparable low-order frequency predictions for reduced and oblate models alongside sharply different condition numbers.

Figure 4: Placeholder for the distinction between forward adequacy and inverse adequacy. The final figure will compare frequency prediction error against inverse conditioning for the reduced and curvature-aware models.

4.4 Conjecture 4: forward adequacy does not imply inverse adequacy

The fourth conjecture is the most practical, and Paper 7 supplies the most useful cautionary example. The equivalent-sphere watermelon model predicts tap-tone frequencies quite reasonably over the relevant stiffness range: f_2 spans 46.4 Hz to 203.2 Hz, and at the canonical reference point the model gives $f_2 = 89.9$ Hz with a clean monotonic relation between f_2^2 and the effective rind modulus E_{rind} [11]. For that task the reduced model is perfectly sensible. Geometry is measured independently; the inverse target is essentially one-dimensional; and the model therefore serves as a practical forward predictor and calibration law.

The trouble begins only when that forward success is promoted into a general inversion claim. If the same equivalent-sphere architecture is asked to recover (a, c, E) jointly from modal data, the condition number returns to the 1×10^{10} scale, because the geometry has again been collapsed into a single radius. The curvature-resolving oblate model, by contrast, yields broadly similar low-order frequencies while restoring a usable inverse map with

$$\kappa = 69.4. \tag{28}$$

Figure 4 is intended to show this distinction: small forward spectral error and good inverse conditioning are related only loosely, and sometimes not at all.

The other applications reinforce the same lesson from different angles. The bladder model predicts a clear forward phenomenon — a minimum $f_2 = 13.5$ Hz at 222 mL — and a clear coupling phenomenon — $\mathcal{R}_{\text{bladder}} \approx 6{,}400$ in favour of mechanical excitation [13]. Neither result, by itself, certifies that a joint inverse problem for geometry and material parameters would be well conditioned. The borborygmi model similarly supports narrow inferences, such as mapping a peak near 340 Hz to a pocket volume of order 3 mL, without claiming that bowel geometry and wall elasticity can be reconstructed uniquely from the sound alone [9]. Forward adequacy is often enough for diagnosis, classification, or design. It is not a licence to ignore identifiability.

Taken together, the four conjectures survive the cross-application synthesis. Equivalent-radius reductions are structurally rank deficient; oblate curvature can lift that defect; the lifting is regular rather than singular near the sphere; and forward predictive success does not guarantee inverse usefulness. That is why the same research programme can contain, without contradiction, a successful equivalent-sphere watermelon model and a strong warning against equivalent-sphere inversion. The models answer different questions. Geometry, as ever, decides which answers are trustworthy.

5 Discussion

The capstone claim of this paper is not simply that geometry matters. That would be a statement of taste, not of mechanism. The stronger conclusion is that geometry enters the problem of fluid-filled viscoelastic shells in three logically distinct ways, and that confusing those roles obscures both the forward physics and the inverse problem. Geometry filters how forcing is projected onto admissible deformation fields; geometry organises the modal spectrum through curvature, symmetry, and fluid loading; and geometry determines whether that spectrum contains enough independent information to recover the parameters that produced it. The four conjectures of Section 3 are best read as consequences of this triple role, rather than as disconnected observations assembled from a sequence of applications.

5.1 Forward adequacy is not inverse adequacy

Of the four conjectures, the deepest is the fourth: forward adequacy does not imply inverse adequacy. A reduced model may reproduce the dominant resonance frequencies of a shell to within a tolerance that is entirely acceptable for classification, screening, or first-pass design, yet remain unusable for parameter recovery because the inverse map is ill-conditioned or effectively singular. The present programme suggests that this decoupling is not an incidental numerical inconvenience. It is geometry mediated.

Equivalent-radius reductions explain the temptation. If the observable of interest is a small set of low-order frequencies, a scalar geometric surrogate can often preserve the leading scale of the answer. Such models compress the problem without obviously destroying the forward spectrum, and that economy is precisely why they remain attractive in practice. What they do not preserve is *separability*. Once independent curvature information has been collapsed into a single scalar descriptor, distinct combinations of geometry and material stiffness can generate nearly indistinguishable spectra. The forward error may remain small while the inverse uncertainty becomes enormous. A model may therefore look persuasive in prediction and still be defective in inference.

This distinction is the most important conceptual result to emerge from the Browntone sequence. The abdominal and sub-bass studies showed that the existence of a resonance is not enough to establish an effective excitation pathway [10, 17]. The watermelon and Kac papers then showed the corresponding inverse statement: the existence of a good spectral fit is not enough to establish a recoverable parameter map [11, 12]. These are parallel lessons. In both cases, geometry selects what can be seen. On the excitation side, it selects which forcing fields project efficiently onto the mode family of interest. On the inverse side, it selects which parameter directions remain distinguishable once those modes are measured. A reduced model that is forward-useful may therefore be inverse-fragile for reasons that are not accidental but structural.

5.2 Why geometry does three jobs

The first job of geometry is filtering. The original brown-note problem made this plain. A fluid-filled oblate shell can support a genuine low-frequency flexural mode near 4 Hz, yet airborne infrasound couples to that mode vanishingly weakly because the long-wavelength forcing field is itself filtered by the geometry of the enclosure [10]. The same mode is far more accessible to

mechanical excitation because whole-body vibration is not subject to the same spatial-harmonic mismatch [17]. Geometry therefore acts as an impedance and projection filter between source and shell response. A resonance may exist without constituting a practical pathway.

The second job is organisation. Fluid-filled shells do not present arbitrary collections of frequencies. Curvature, aspect ratio, internal loading, and wall compliance sort the admissible motions into structured spectral families. In the abdominal problem, this distinguishes the low-frequency flexural modes from the much higher breathing mode dominated by fluid compressibility [10]. In the bladder, changing fill state alters both size and effective stiffness, producing a resonance trajectory that is not captured by a single monotonic size law [13]. In the gas-pocket and borborygmi papers, confinement and cavity geometry organise a different but related band of observable oscillations [14, 9]. Across applications, geometry is the quiet organiser of what the spectrum is allowed to look like before any inversion begins.

The third job is inversion, and this is the capstone contribution. Geometry governs which parameter directions are distinguishable in spectral space. When symmetry is high, mode sensitivities tend to align and the scaled Jacobian loses rank or becomes badly conditioned. When symmetry is broken in a way that creates genuinely different curvature sampling across modes, the sensitivity columns separate and inversion becomes possible. The rank-deficiency, identifiability-lifting, and near-spherical-conditioning conjectures are all different ways of stating that fact. Geometry is not merely an input to the forward problem. It is the source of the information one hopes to recover from the spectrum.

5.3 Oblate–prolate asymmetry is a selectivity result

It would be tempting to interpret the inverse results as evidence that any departure from spherical symmetry is beneficial. The present evidence does not support so universal a reading. The oblate–prolate comparison instead suggests a more selective conclusion: some symmetry breakings produce useful modal differentiation, whereas others do not. Oblate geometries appear especially effective because they induce mode-dependent curvature sampling that decorrelates the parameter sensitivities. Prolate geometries, at least in the regimes so far examined, need not do so.

This matters because it changes how reduced models should be judged. If the aim is only to capture the leading frequency scale, an equivalent sphere may remain an entirely sensible first approximation, and oblate and prolate corrections may appear equally modest at the level of forward error. If the aim is parameter recovery, however, the choice of reduced geometry becomes part of the inverse design problem. A reduction that preserves mean size while erasing curvature contrast may destroy identifiability; a reduction that retains the wrong kind of asphericity may improve very little. The asymmetry is therefore a selectivity result, not a universality result. Not all symmetry breaking helps, and reduced models should be assessed by the sensitivity structure they preserve, not by forward residuals alone.

That conclusion has broader methodological force. In many practical inverse problems, model reduction is justified *a posteriori* by a small mismatch in the predicted observables. The present results suggest a stricter criterion. A reduction is acceptable only if it preserves the geometry-induced information structure required by the inference task. That is a harder requirement, but it is the honest one.

5.4 What the cross-application evidence establishes

Taken individually, the Browntone papers addressed local questions. Could a human abdominal cavity possess a low-frequency flexural resonance? Could a tissue-constrained gas pocket radiate in the audible band? How does bladder fill state alter resonance? Can tap-tone data support inversion in a watermelon? Does asphericity lift inverse degeneracy? The capstone claim is that these are not merely entertaining detours. They instantiate a common mechanism in which geometry governs forcing pathways, spectral structure, and identifiability in tandem.

The evidence, however, is not uniform, and it should not be presented as though it were. Papers 1, 2, and 6 speak most directly to filtering: excitation is geometry selective, and the same resonance can be practically invisible to one forcing pathway yet accessible to another [10, 14, 17]. Papers 3, 4, and 5 speak most clearly to organisation: geometric scaling, fill state, and confinement sort the spectrum into coherent families [16, 13, 9]. Papers 7 and 8 bear most directly on inversion, because they expose the tension between a satisfactory forward fit and a recoverable parameter map [11, 12]. What the programme establishes, then, is not a formal theorem but a coherent synthesis: apparently disparate vibroacoustic phenomena in fluid-filled shells can be read as manifestations of one geometry-mediated structure.

5.5 Limitations

Several limitations should be stated plainly. First, the present theory relies on a Ritz approximation. That is a reasonable and economical way to capture the low-order modal structure of smooth axisymmetric shells, but it remains an approximation. A richer basis, higher-order shell theory, or full finite-element verification would be desirable, especially in parameter regimes where modal veering or stronger fluid–structure interaction becomes important.

Secondly, the kinematics are intentionally reduced. The low-dimensional shell description isolates the dominant meridional and radial content required for the present conjectures, but it cannot represent the full deformation space of a real viscoelastic enclosure. This simplification is analytically productive and predictively limiting in equal measure.

Thirdly, the capstone is theoretical rather than experimental. No dedicated phantom measurements or in vivo data have yet been used to test the inverse claims directly. The present conclusions should therefore be read as analytically supported and cross-application consistent, rather than experimentally closed.

Fourthly, the model class is intentionally narrow: thin elastic shells, single-fluid filling, small deformations, and linear response. Real biological and engineering enclosures may be layered, anisotropic, prestressed, spatially heterogeneous, or only approximately shell-like. Likewise, the surrounding supports and boundary conditions in vivo are more complicated than those represented here. Finally, the analysis remains confined to the linear regime and therefore excludes contact, finite strain, geometric stiffening, and other nonlinear effects that may become important in some applications.

These limitations do not negate the present argument, but they do mark its proper scope. The four conjectures concern the geometric structure of spectral inference in a deliberately clean model class. Whether they survive, and in what modified form, under greater constitutive and geometric realism is precisely the next question.

5.6 Future directions

The most immediate next step is experimental validation. Phantom studies with controlled oblate and prolate shells would allow direct measurement of modal frequencies, damping, and inverse conditioning under known geometry and material properties. Such experiments matter because the capstone claims concern *parameter recovery*, not merely forward resonance. It is not enough to observe the correct frequency shift. One must test whether the recovered parameters are stable, repeatable, and geometry dependent in the predicted way. If that programme succeeds, in vivo measurements would provide the more difficult but more consequential test of whether the same structure persists in biological variability.

A second direction is theoretical extension beyond the linear thin-shell setting. Layered walls, anisotropy, prestress, nonlinear kinematics, and more realistic fluid–structure coupling may all alter the conditioning landscape. A particularly important question is which features of the present picture are robust consequences of symmetry and curvature, and which depend more delicately on the present reduced shell model.

A third direction is application. The same spectral-mechanics template may be useful for other compliant enclosures in biomechanics, soft robotics, membrane-lined vessels, industrial casings, and postharvest systems. In noise, vibration, and harshness, non-destructive testing, and biomedical sensing, one often seeks to infer internal state from sparse spectral observables. The present work suggests that success in such tasks may depend less on constitutive ornament and more on understanding which geometric features create distinguishable modal signatures.

Finally, the conjectures themselves deserve formal mathematical proof. The rank-deficiency and identifiability-lifting claims should be placed on a sharper analytical footing, the near-spherical asymptotics should be derived explicitly, and the oblate–prolate selectivity should be characterised beyond the regimes so far examined. If the programme began with a question that nobody was obliged to take seriously, it ends in a rather more respectable place: a set of tractable mathematical problems about symmetry, curvature, and information in shell spectra.

6 Conclusion

This paper has argued that the Browntone programme is best understood not as a collection of curious applications, but as a coherent theory of geometry in fluid-filled compliant shells. The central thesis is that geometry does three jobs. It filters how external forcing couples into admissible shell motions; it organises the modal spectrum through symmetry, curvature, and fluid loading; and it determines whether the spectrum can be inverted to recover the parameters that generated it. That thesis emerged first from the abdominal and sub-bass problems, broadened through bladder, gas-pocket, scaling-law, and borborygmi studies, and reached its sharpest form in the inverse analyses of watermelon acoustics and organ-shape identifiability [10, 14, 16, 13, 9, 17, 11, 12].

Within that framework, four conjectures have been stated and supported. The first is that equivalent-radius reductions of non-spherical fluid-filled shells are generically rank deficient, because they collapse independent geometric information into a single size parameter. The second is that asphericity can lift that deficiency by allowing different modes to sample curvature differently. The third is that the transition to the spherical limit is a conditioning problem, not merely a perturbation problem: as symmetry is restored, the inverse map becomes fragile

even when the forward spectrum remains well approximated. The fourth, and perhaps most consequential, is that forward adequacy does not imply inverse adequacy. A model may predict frequencies well enough to look convincing while remaining unsuitable for parameter recovery.

The cross-application evidence suggests, moreover, that identifiability lifting is geometry selective rather than universal. Oblate perturbations appear able to generate the modal differentiation needed for stable inversion, whereas prolate perturbations need not do so. Reduced models for spectral inference should therefore be judged not only by forward accuracy, but by whether they preserve the geometry-induced sensitivity structure required by the inverse task.

We have been careful not to overstate what has been established. The capstone is analytical, not experimental. The shell models are linear, thin, and intentionally reduced. The conjectures are strongly supported across applications, but they are not yet formal theorems. Even so, a sufficiently consistent picture has emerged to support a broader claim: spectral mechanics in fluid-filled compliant enclosures can be organised around geometry as an information-bearing structure, rather than treated as a collection of isolated frequency calculations.

That perspective offers a template for future work in biomechanics, biomedical sensing, non-destructive testing, and industrial noise, vibration, and harshness. Wherever one seeks to infer internal state, material condition, or geometry from sparse resonance data, the same question arises: which aspects of shape are merely descriptive, and which make the inverse problem possible? The present programme suggests that this is the right question to ask first.

If one permits a final compression of the argument into a single sentence, it is this: the joke was never the point. Geometry was. The next tasks are therefore clear. The conjectures should be tested experimentally in phantoms and, where feasible, in vivo; the framework should be extended to nonlinear and more realistic shell models; and the analytical claims should be converted into formal proofs. Those steps would not change the direction of the present paper. They would make it harder to ignore.

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Table 1: Cross-application evidence for the geometry–spectrum–inference thesis. Here f_2 denotes the lowest flexural mode, R_{eq} the equivalent radius where used, and κ the condition number of the scaled Jacobian for the local inverse problem.

Application	Geometry and key parameters	Characteristic frequencies	Coupling / inference takeaway
Abdomen	Canonical oblate shell: $a = 0.18\,\mathrm{m}$, $c = 0.12\,\mathrm{m}$, $h = 0.01\,\mathrm{m}$, $E = 0.1\,\mathrm{MPa}$, $\nu = 0.45$, $\rho_f = 1020\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}$, $R_{\mathrm{eq}} = 0.157\,\mathrm{m}$	$f_2 = 3.95\,\mathrm{Hz}$; higher flexural modes in the 4 Hz to 10 Hz band; breathing mode $n = 0$ near 2490 Hz	Geometry filters forcing as well as spectra: the reported mechanical-to-airborne displacement ratio is $R \approx 3.3 \times 10^4$ in the canonical comparison; the same geometry underpins the identifiability study with $\kappa_{\mathrm{oblate}} = 69.4$
Bladder	Fill-dependent near-spherical shell over 50 mL to 500 mL; representative 300 mL state: $R = 4.15\,\mathrm{cm}$, $h = 1.79\,\mathrm{mm}$, $E = 70.9\,\mathrm{kPa}$	U-shaped $f_2(V)$ curve with a minimum $f_2 = 13.5\,\mathrm{Hz}$ at 222 mL; representative 300 mL value $f_2 = 13.9\,\mathrm{Hz}$	Geometry and strain-stiffening jointly organise the spectrum; mechanical coupling exceeds airborne coupling by $\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{bladder}} \approx 6{,}400$; useful fill-state inference is possible, but no full geometry–material inversion is claimed
Watermelon	Oblate fruit approximated by an equivalent sphere: $a = 0.158\,\mathrm{m}$, $c = 0.123\,\mathrm{m}$, $h = 15\,\mathrm{mm}$, $R_{\mathrm{eq}} = 0.1453\,\mathrm{m}$, $E_{\mathrm{rind}} = 10\,\mathrm{MPa}$ to $250\,\mathrm{MPa}$	Tap-tone flexural frequency $f_2 = 46.4\,\mathrm{Hz}$ to $203.2\,\mathrm{Hz}$ across the constructed stiffness sweep; canonical example $f_2 = 89.9\,\mathrm{Hz}$ at $E_{\mathrm{rind}} = 50\,\mathrm{MPa}$	Equivalent-sphere reduction is forward-useful when geometry is measured independently and the inverse target is one effective stiffness parameter; that same reduction is unsuitable for joint recovery of (a, c, E)
Borborygmi	Quasi-spherical or slug-like gas pockets in a 30 mm lumen; canonical constrained-bubble parameters: $V = 1\,\mathrm{mL}$ to $50\,\mathrm{mL}$, $E = 10\,\mathrm{kPa}$, $h = 3\,\mathrm{mm}$	Constrained-bubble resonance 135 Hz to 440 Hz; canonical 10 mL pocket: 223 Hz; healthy spectral peak near 340 Hz implies $V \sim 3\,\mathrm{mL}$	Geometry selects the active resonance family; narrow inference about pocket size or mechanism is plausible, but only because the inverse task is low-dimensional rather than a full shell identification problem